

## **AM I HAVING DIFFICULTY LETTING GO?**

### **GOALS OF THE EXERCISE**

1. Accept a loss and increase social contact with others.
2. Recognize and understand emotions regarding loss that may be unresolved.
3. Increase insight into specific aspects of loss that may be unresolved.
4. Identify any areas in which the client will need additional assistance in achieving resolution.

### **ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE UNRESOLVED GRIEF OR LOSS**

- Building My Support Network
- Coping with Addiction and Mood Disorders or Bereavement
- Handling Crisis
- Identifying and Using Community Resources
- Learning to Self-Soothe
- Moving on with My Life
- Safe and Peaceful Place Meditation
- Understanding Spirituality
- Using My Support Network

### **ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL**

- Adult-Child-of-an-Alcoholic (ACOA) Traits
- Borderline Traits
- Childhood Trauma
- Dependent Traits
- Living Environment Deficiencies
- Posttraumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD)

### **SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT**

The “Am I Having Difficulty Letting Go?” activity is designed for the client who may have trouble understanding his/her issues related to unresolved grief or loss. It also can be useful with the client who is very aware that he/she has grief issues to resolve but does not know how to begin or how to get unstuck. The exercise can be tailored to ad-

dress grief reactions for losses other than bereavement. Additionally, it is important to process the client's views about death and dying and loss in general, as these can be influenced by cultural factors. Follow-up can include processing the exercise with the therapist or group; designing and conducting a mourning and letting-go ritual; and the assignment titled "Moving on with My Life." **Note: it is vital to take immediate and effective action if a client reports suicidal ideation, intent, or behavior.**

## AM I HAVING DIFFICULTY LETTING GO?

Grief and sorrow can be related to the death of a loved one, the end of a relationship, the loss of a job, a catastrophic illness, a major financial loss, or any other serious personal setback. The loss may have been either expected or unexpected. For people coping with addictions, these losses might be related directly to their addictive behaviors and lifestyles, or unrelated. Sometimes these losses occur well into a person's recovery, and inability to cope with loss can put him/her at risk of relapsing into addictive behavior to deal with painful emotions. Additionally, losses that occurred while we were actively engaged in addictive behaviors may not be resolved for us and may act as relapse triggers in early, late, or middle recovery if healing does not occur. While very personal and painful, healthy resolution of loss requires and begins with assessing whether we have losses that are unresolved. This exercise will guide you through the process of reflecting on whether unresolved grief is a recovery or treatment issue for you and what your unresolved losses might be.

1. Following is a list of signs that may indicate that you are dealing with an unresolved loss (old or new). These are normal, not abnormal, reactions to loss. Please check all that apply to you.
  - Inability to stop talking about the loss
  - Avoiding talking or thinking about certain subjects
  - Replaying what you feel you should have done differently
  - Feeling or believing that if you express any emotion about the loss, it will take over (e.g., feeling that if you start crying you won't be able to stop, that if you express your anger you'll go out of control)
  - Disbelief that the loss occurred
  - Withdrawing from others or isolating
  - Becoming overwhelmed and disorganized
  - Having trouble sleeping or eating
  - Feeling apathetic or numb
  - Having difficulty concentrating
  - Feeling guilty about the loss
  - Feeling as if you're falling apart
  - Feeling hopeless about the situation, or your feelings, ever changing
  - Feeling a lack of control in other areas of your life

- Feeling betrayed
- Having suicidal thoughts **(If you are thinking about killing or hurting yourself, share this with your therapist immediately and ask for help to stay safe—these thoughts will pass if you do whatever it takes to avoid acting on them.)**
- Feeling anger and resentment
- Feeling dissatisfied with everything or everyone
- Feeling a lack of purpose
- Having a sense of failure or worthlessness
- Other:

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2. What loss, losses, or traumatic event do you believe are related to the signs you checked in question 1?

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3. What methods of coping with these losses or traumatic events have worked for you? How did they help and how did they not help?

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4. What has been the most difficult aspect of thinking about letting go (e.g., do you feel you would be abandoning or betraying someone you lost if you let yourself heal)?

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5. Please list any fears you may have about letting go or moving on?

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6. On which item that you chose from the list would you like to begin working first?

Be sure to bring this exercise back to your next session with your therapist, and be prepared to discuss your thoughts and feelings about the exercise.